



SUMIT INDER SINGH

youngsters under the media glare right from day one and would reduce their confidence.

When I addressed the students on the first day, I told them that this project was a historic event that would demonstrate how a group of 89 committed, disciplined and aspirational students from disadvantaged communities, combined with a group of missionary and committed teachers, could prove a new model to eradicate social injustice. I told them that the success of this model depended primarily on them and that they carried a huge responsibility. The programme got off to a wonderful start on October 9, 2006. As expected, Sadagopan, Ravindra, the extraordinary faculty from IIT-B and Infosys and Pai worked hard and smart to complete the course.

We studied the average performance of the students under the programme in the 12 tests we administered during the course. In 10 out of the 12 tests, the average performance was nearly the same as the highly rigorous Infosys course, proving the point that given attention, quality teachers, facilities and care, the disadvantaged students could perform as good as any. When these students completed their course on May 1, 2007, they were interviewed by well-known software companies like Bally Systems, Canara Bank, HP, IBM, Iflex, Infosys, MindTree, Mphasis and Wipro. On the day of the convocation, an amazing 84 out of 89 students had been placed in these companies, thus meeting the criterion of placement of at least 90 per cent of the students for us to deem this experiment a success. Mrs Kumar and the then chief minister of Karnataka H.D. Kumaraswamy, graced the convocation held on June 23 and distributed certificates to the confident students who had demonstrated that they were as good as any and better than many. Mrs

Advantage point:
Given attention, quality teachers, facilities and care, all students are equal

Trained to Conquer

SOCIAL INJUSTICE CAN BE ERADICATED IN INDIA. THE CHALLENGE IS TO EMPOWER PEOPLE WHO CAN DO SO. AND THAT'S POSSIBLE ONLY THROUGH GREAT LEADERSHIP.

Kumar was very happy with this experiment and congratulated the youngsters and the extraordinary teachers. These students meet me once a year and tell me how well they are doing in their jobs. As of this writing, STP students are employed in USA, Nigeria, Germany, India and Australia—spanning five continents. All but one of the 84 students have completed their year-long probation successfully.

We are repeating this experiment in several states and we hope that it will prove that the solution to the problem of social injustice is not reservation as it will damage the psyche of the youngsters permanently. The solution is to invest heavily in producing high-quality, committed teachers and create incentives for them to provide special attention to the disadvantaged children right from primary schools. The Government should also provide tuition fees in top schools, good nutrition and hostel facilities to these children. As the wonderful young men and women from the STP, and the extraordinary teachers from IIT-B and Infosys demonstrated, nothing much can be achieved without aspiration, hard work, discipline and commitment. This experiment has proved to me that it is possible to eradicate social injustice in India in a very constructive and positive way. The challenge is to find people like Sadagopan and his inspiring band of IIT-B teachers, Ravindra and his committed Infosys colleagues, and Pai. A country like India should have a large number of such terrific people. Leadership is identifying such people and empowering them to lead initiatives like these. This is what that great man, Jawaharlal Nehru, did so effortlessly.

The author is the non-executive chairman and chief mentor of Infosys Technologies.